

Day 2 — Caraka Saṃhitā: Primary Source Reading

Module: Ayurveda (Senior) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students read selected verses from Caraka Saṃhitā Sūtra-sthāna in IAST + translation, identifying Caraka’s definition of *āyu* (life) and his epistemological framework.

Materials

- Printed handout: Caraka Sūtra-sthāna 1.41–45 (definition of *āyu*) in IAST + translation
- Optional: Caraka Sūtra-sthāna 11 (pramāṇa — means of valid knowledge)

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

Recall: 3 foundational texts; 4 of the 8 branches.

Reading (25 min)

1. **Caraka’s definition of *āyu*** (Sūtra-sthāna 1.42):

śarīrendryasattvātmasaṃyogo dhāri jīvitam nityagaścānubandhaśca paryāyair āyur ucyate

“The conjunction of body, senses, mind, and self — which sustains [life] — is called *jīvita* (life). Persistent and connected — these are synonyms for *āyu*.”

Word-by-word:

- *śarīra* = body
- *indrya* = senses
- *sattva* = mind
- *ātma* = self
- *saṃyogo* = conjunction, union
- *dhāri* = sustainer
- *jīvitam* = life

Note the move: *āyu* = body + senses + mind + self. **A four-component definition of life.** Not just biology — includes psychology and the witnessing self.

2. **Caraka’s epistemology (Sūtra-sthāna 11).** Three pramāṇas (means of valid knowledge):

- *Āpta-upadeśa* — authoritative teaching (testimony)
- *Pratyakṣa* — direct perception
- *Anumāna* — inference

Note: this is essentially the same epistemological framework that the Nyāya school formalised (with one additional pramāṇa — comparison). Caraka was working within an articulated philosophy of knowledge.

3. Discussion:

- How does Caraka's 4-component āyu compare with the modern biomedical view of "life"?
- The pramāṇa framework predates Aristotle's *Posterior Analytics* in important ways. Compare.

Activity (10 min)

Quiet reading. Students annotate the verse handout. Note one question.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Preview Day 3: "*Tomorrow — Tridosha theory in classical depth + modern engagement.*"

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Read Sūtra-sthāna ch. 11 in full (Sharma 1981 translation).
- **Tier down:** Focus on the āyu definition; the pramāṇa material is bonus.

Teacher notes

- Caraka's text is dense. Don't try to cover everything. The āyu definition + the pramāṇa naming are enough.
- The "mind + self" inclusion in life surprises students raised on a body-only definition. Honour the surprise.

Citation(s) used

- Caraka Sūtra-sthāna 1.42 — Sharma (1981).
- vidya-karana RAG day-01-intro.json for supporting Bhagavad-gītā references.